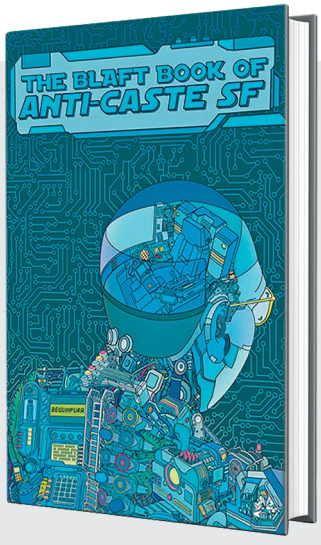
BOOKS

REALITY CHECK

The Blaft Book of Anti-Caste SF is a must-read collection of dark tales lit by flashes of wry, sardonic humour



The Blaft Book of Anti-Caste SF
Edited by R.T. Samuel, Rakesh K., Rashmi R.D.
BLAFT PUBLICATIONS
₹995; 450 pages

Reading this book is like jumping aboard a space-craft made of stories, to hunt down the demons that have haunted Indo-South Asia for centuries.

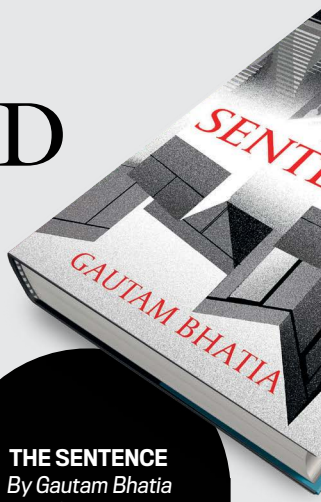
Caste-based intolerance is the main bogey, of course. But gender-based injustice, power differentials and raw hypocrisy share the stage equally. The stories are dark, but lit by flashes of wry, sardonic humour. Out of 30 tales, eight are translated from other Indian languages. All of them include italicised words that don't have simple counterparts in English, with explanations in the 'Notes' at the back of the book.

I wondered about the title. Would the book have been more sincerely "anti-caste" had it made no reference to caste at all in the title? Doesn't this formulation lead us to think

BOOKS

MINEFIELD OF IDEAS

Being a lawyer, Gautam Bhatia is uniquely placed to address ideas at the intersection of politics and morality, as he does in *The Sentence*, his latest work of speculative fiction



THE SENTENCE
By Gautam Bhatia
WESTLAND/IF
₹599; 396 pages

In *Star Wars: The Empire Strikes Back*, the dashing Han Solo (Harrison Ford) is 'frozen' in solid carbonite casing by the film's villain, Darth Vader. He isn't dead (yet) but he is in a state of reversible hibernation. A similar punishment lies at the heart of Gautam Bhatia's work of speculative fiction, *The Sentence*. The narrative is set in the mining-led city-state of Peruma, which has always faced tense relations between capital and labour, dwelling in the 'Council' and the 'Commune', respectively. A hundred years before the events of the novel, a man named Jagat allegedly murdered a high-ranking Council official, because of which he was sentenced to 'cryo-sleep', a state of cryogenic hibernation not entirely unlike Han Solo's. And now, almost a century later, the novel's protagonist, a Guardian (think of it as a lawyer, but with extra steps and soothing noises about honour and duty)